

FIELD LIBRARY / ACTION CHECKLIST

Preparedness on a limited budget

PREPAREDNESS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Start with a household plan, written contacts and supplies you already own. Prioritize drinking water, essential medicines, food you normally eat and safe light. Build gradually without taking money away from urgent household needs.

Do now.

- ☐ **Inventory before buying**
01 Check usable water containers, lights, batteries, food, clothing and charging options. Record quantities, expiry dates and gaps.
- ☐ **Choose one realistic priority**
02 Match the first purchase to a likely disruption and a person's essential need. A medicine or water gap matters more than specialist gadgets.
- ☐ **Build into normal routines**
03 Add a small amount of shelf-stable food or water when affordable. Rotate what the household actually uses and can prepare safely.
- ☐ **Make free planning changes**
04 Write emergency contacts, choose meeting places, save guides and learn safe shutoffs. Practice an exit route and check warning access.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Plan around actual carrying capacity, storage, transport and money. Identify safe mutual support before a crisis, but confirm what a neighbor or group can provide. A borrowed item is only useful when it will be accessible during the disruption.

Watch for.

Do not buy unsafe used safety equipment, store fuel improperly or ration essential medication to build a kit. No shopping list guarantees survival.

People & practical needs.

Ask each person what they need to function without power or transport. Include sensory access, infant feeding, pets and medical routines

Next decision.

Revisit one gap at a time. Check a kit when food or medication rotates, after household changes and before the local hazard season.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

INCIDENT / SYMPTOM ONSET / LOCATION

HELP REQUESTED / RESPONSE CONFIRMED

SOURCES / SCOPE / LIMITS

Source-linked civilian guidance, not independent clinical or specialist certification. U.S. references; emergency numbers and services differ. Training and product instructions remain essential.

[Ready.gov – Low and no-cost preparedness](#)

[Ready.gov – Build a kit](#)

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/preparedness/budget-preparedness/>